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DECLINE

WITH THE new millennium came a wave of cricketing chaos.

In early 2000, the Delhi police charged then South African skipper, Hansie Cronje, with match-fixing. Eventually, the ICC slapped a life ban on him. The same year, Pakistan's Saleem Malik and Ata-ur-Rahman also received life bans when faced with the same charges. By the end of the year, then Indian skipper, Mohammad Azharuddin, along with Ajay Jadeja, were also barred from playing the game. Once the 1999 World Cup ended, there was a global inquisition against the menace of corruption in cricket. The time had come to clean things up. Heads began to roll.

By the end of 2001, the cricketing world lost its greatest icon: Sir Donald Bradman, who died at the age of ninety-two. I regret not meeting him, even though I'd toured Australia. And even while the match-fixing saga was taking the subcontinent by storm, Australia were on a roll, the undisputed leaders of Test cricket, clocking 16 straight Test wins. Their professionalism was so good, it was scary.

Unfortunately, 2001 was also the year when terror, in its modern form, unleashed on Pakistan. First there were the 9/11 attacks in the US, which shocked the world and then, soon after, shook our region, as the war in Afghanistan spilled over into Pakistan. In January 2002, Pakistan was forced to shift a Test series against the West Indies to Sharjah, as the Windies had turned down an invitation to visit Pakistan, citing security concerns. By summer that year, the Kiwis came over on tour – Inzi hit a brilliant 329 in Lahore – but once there was a bomb blast outside our hotel in Karachi, apparently targeting some French engineers, not us, our matches were called off. Worse still, Hansie Cronje, once among the game's most distinguished captains until the match-fixing controversy ended his career, died in a plane crash. Both in geopolitics and cricket, there was violence and volatility.

But amidst it all, I clearly remember that bombing in Karachi. We were at breakfast in the Pearl Continental, right across the street from the Sheraton. The lads were hanging out at